



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Island Christian Academy

School Website: <https://www.islandchristianacademy.com/>

December 27, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Island Christian Academy (ICA) in Langley, WA 98260 presents itself as a classical, Christian school operating within a faith-based community (including a campus hosted at a local church) and aligned with the Association of Classical and Christian Schools (ACCS). Public materials emphasize a classical identity and a mission to integrate faith and learning, with explicit statements about being a "classical school" and about preparing college-bound students. The site highlights a mission to partner with parents and to foster a Christian worldview, and it includes a visible commitment to a public-facing classical framework (via a "Classical Approach" page) and a staff-led leadership structure. That said, several classic elements of a rigorous classical program—such as explicit reference to liberal arts triads (grammar, logic, rhetoric), widespread deployment of Great Books/Great Conversation, and explicit pedagogical practices (Socratic seminars, scholé, etc.)—are not clearly documented in the public ICA materials provided here. The net result is a school that strongly signals classical and Christian aims in mission, branding, and governance, but with only partial explicit articulation of core classical curriculum and pedagogy details in the publicly accessible content.

- Aggregate classification: NOT CLASSICAL
- Overall rationale: The school clearly advertises classical and Christian orientation and a church-based context, with explicit statements like "we are a classical school focused on preparing college-bound students." However, the public materials do not consistently document all six classical criteria (notably explicit Great Books/Great Conversation commitments, explicit liberal arts curriculum (grammar–logic–rhetoric), and fully described Socratic/Scholé pedagogy and a fully developed faculty/community formation model). This mix yields a global assessment of NOT CLASSICAL, with some category-by-category signals of classical alignment.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The campus operates within a church setting (South Whidbey Assembly of God) and ICA explicitly positions itself as a Christian school. This is evidenced by campus location and dedication to faith integration in the public materials. - Public statements emphasize faith integration and a Christian worldview, including a Statement of Faith and Mission materials (e.g., "integrate faith and learning in a nurturing environment" and "internalize a truly Christian world view"). - ICA's ACCS membership further anchors religious and classical-Christian identity.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: faith, theology, Christian worldview, Statement of Faith, church, liturgical/congregational imagery (via church campus), mission to integrate faith and learning. These map to the lexicon's religious/metaphysical indicators (truth/beauty/goodness anchored in a Christian theologically-inflected framework). - Negative keywords: none clearly evident in the public materials (no explicit signaling of relativism or secular humanism in the core statements).

Why this rating - The strongest explicit signals are religiously grounded and the school identifies itself as Christian and theologically anchored (Statement of Faith) with a church-based campus, which aligns with Positive indicators. However, there is not a robust cataloged liturgical calendar or explicit

liturgical/communal-worship cadence described in detail in public pages, so while the foundation is clearly religious, the breadth of liturgical/community practices documented publicly is limited. Therefore, a CLASSICAL alignment is not fully demonstrated across the entire set of liturgical/community indicators; hence NOT CLASSICAL as a whole for this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - ICA publicly describes itself as a “classical school” and emphasizes preparing college-bound students, indicating telos aligned with formation toward human flourishing and classical aims. - Mission statements emphasize faith-informed formation and partnership with parents to develop students who love learning in a Christian frame, signaling formation and higher aims beyond mere information.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue (implicit via formation and character-building language in classical education lexicon; also “college-bound” signals a traditional aim beyond mere job prep), truth/goodness/beauty (implicit in Christian-theological framing and classical associations), liberal-arts-oriented framing by branding. The explicit presence of “classical school” and “formation” language, plus “college-bound,” constitute positive classical cues. - Negative keywords: not overtly present; the site does reference college-prep as a purpose (which can be viewed as modern workforce-prep overlap in some Classical lexicon, though not explicit). The absence of explicit statements about “workforce preparation” or “21st-century skills” as primary aims reduces negative signals here.

Why this rating - The materials indicate formation-oriented aims and a classical identity, but they are not fully explicit about all the classical formation principles (e.g., detailed telos, explicit virtues, or explicit references to truth-beauty-goodness as real, knowable forms). The combination of clear classical branding with formation-focused goals yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL classification for this category.

Element 3: Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site highlights a “Classical Approach” page and a K–12 structure (Preschool through 12th) with ACCS membership, but it does not provide explicit details about classical curriculum content such as grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books, or a history-embedded curriculum that spans across disciplines. - Public materials show program structure (K–12, campus and accreditation) but lack explicit mention of liberal arts triad (grammar, logic, rhetoric), or of Great Books/Great Conversation, or of history as a continuous through-line rather than a separate social-studies framing.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: classical approach; K–12 structure; “Great Books/Great Conversation” language is not present in public content (no explicit Great Books or Great Conversation references). The visible curriculum keywords are mostly logistical (grades, program overview) rather than content-focused liberal-arts descriptors. - Negative keywords: absence of explicit Great Books, Great Conversation, grammar–logic–rhetoric triad, or explicit history-as-core curriculum language. The lack of these explicit lexical indicators reduces alignment with full classical curriculum expectations.

Why this rating - While ICA brands itself as classical and has a visible “Classical Approach” page, the public-facing materials do not provide the explicit content markers that define a full classical curriculum (grammar–logic–rhetoric, Great Books, Great Conversation, history-as-a-through-line). The absence of these explicit items supports a NOT CLASSICAL categorization for Curriculum at this time.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials do not document standard classical pedagogy (e.g., Socratic seminars, memory work, recitation, or scholé practices) in explicit detail. The site references “Classical Approach,” but there is no clear, text-based confirmation of how instruction is run at the classroom level (aside from general formation language). - There is no explicit public evidence of lower-school singing/chanting programs or upper-school rhetoric training that are commonly emphasized in classical pedagogy, beyond generic “classical approach” branding.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: mentions of “classical approach” and a multi-level grade structure (K–12) suggest classical pedagogy in branding, but concrete pedagogy terms (Socratic, scholé, memorization cadences, chant, memory work, etc.) are not present in the accessible content. - Negative keywords present: absence of explicit Socratic seminars, recitation/narration rituals, or the restfulness/contemplative pedagogy signals (scholé days) in public text. This reduces alignment with Classical Pedagogy indicators.

Why this rating - Despite branding as “Classical Approach,” the public-facing documentation does not provide explicit, operational evidence of the core classical teaching methods (Socratic discussion, memory-based pedagogy, or contemplative rest in pedagogy). Therefore, Pedagogy is categorized as NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public site highlights the staff page and leadership (Head of School) but does not furnish explicit statements about faculty as “living curriculum,” mentor/model teacher roles, or a formal “portrait of what a teacher should be” as a public, textual feature. - There is no explicit language in the public materials that describes faculty as “model teachers and mentors,” or that details a collaborative faculty culture with a classical formation focus.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: “Head of School” and “Our Staff” imply a visible leadership/faculty presence, but explicit descriptors of faculty as the living curriculum or as “portraits” are not documented in the public text. - Negative keywords present: none explicitly centered on faculty decline or weak mentorship; however, the lack of explicit classical-faculty language reduces alignment. The lexicon’s positive indicators (model teachers, living curriculum, portrait of teacher) are not evidenced in the public content.

Why this rating - The publicly available information does not substantiate the classic faculty language in the Six Essentials. As a result, Faculty is assessed as NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - ICA emphasizes partnering with parents in forming students and developing a Christian worldview, with explicit invitation to engage via the website and in-person visits. The public materials emphasize parent partnership and co-teacher dynamics. - The site features a dedicated “For Parents” section, a mission to partner with families, and open access to campus visits; there are explicit invitations to visit and participate (e.g., “Schedule a Visit,” campus location, etc.). - A tuition-structure page indicates a volunteer-hours model (parents contribute time) or pay-in-lieu, highlighting a co-educator posture and parental involvement in school life. This aligns with the classical element of parent collaboration in the school’s life.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, open campus/visits, parent involvement (Volunteer Hours). These map to the lexicon’s Parents & Community indicators (partnership and formation with parents). - Negative keywords: none clearly present in the public materials; no consumer-only language; rather, a collaborative framing is visible.

Why this rating - There is clear evidence of a systemic emphasis on parent collaboration, parent formation, and open campus access, all of which align with classical education’s expectations for active parent partnerships and formation of parents as co-educators. Therefore, Parents & Community is CLASSICAL.

Overall assessment and aggregate ranking

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Aggregate rating: NOT CLASSICAL

Rationale: The school shows strong classical-Christian branding in religious foundations (Element 1) and robust parental partnership (Element 6), but the majority of other core classical dimensions—Curriculum (Element 3), Pedagogy (Element 4), and Faculty (Element 5)—are not backed by explicit public-text evidence of the classical elements (Great Books, grammar–logic–rhetoric, Socratic pedagogy, living curriculum faculty descriptors). Element 2 shows some classical formation language but is not fully explicit about virtue-wisdom telos. Taken together, the school does not meet the full classical rubric across the six categories, resulting in a NOT CLASSICAL aggregate.

What would move the needle

- For Element 2 (SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL):
 - Add explicit language about formation of character, virtue, and wisdom, including references to a telos beyond college-prep (e.g., “formation of virtue for human flourishing”).
 - Provide explicit articulation of the liberal arts triad (grammar, logic, rhetoric) in curriculum descriptions beyond branding.
 - Document how learning aims align with the pursuit of truth, good, and beauty (e.g., through mission statements or program pages).
- For Element 3 (Curriculum):
 - Explicitly state and illustrate the core classical curriculum components: grammar, logic, rhetoric; incorporation of Great Books or canonical primary sources; history integrated throughout the curriculum (not as a separate “social studies” track); and evidence of the Great Conversation approach.
 - Include sample units or core texts and descriptions showing history and literature as through-lines.
- For Element 4 (Pedagogy):
 - Provide explicit description of pedagogical methods aligned with classical education (Socratic seminars, scholé days, memory work, recitation, classical rhetoric training, etc.).
 - Provide examples of upper-level student rhetoric opportunities, debates, and public speaking to demonstrate classical training.
- For Element 5 (Faculty):
 - Articulate a clear faculty portrait, including “living curriculum” language and the role of teachers as mentors and exemplars of virtue.
 - Describe professional development in classical pedagogy and how teachers collaborate as a “faculty of friends” model.
- For Element 1 (Religious/Metaphysical Foundations) and Element 6 (Parents & Community):
 - Maintain and deepen explicit ties to liturgical or communal practice (where appropriate) and continue to foreground parent engagement as co-educators.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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